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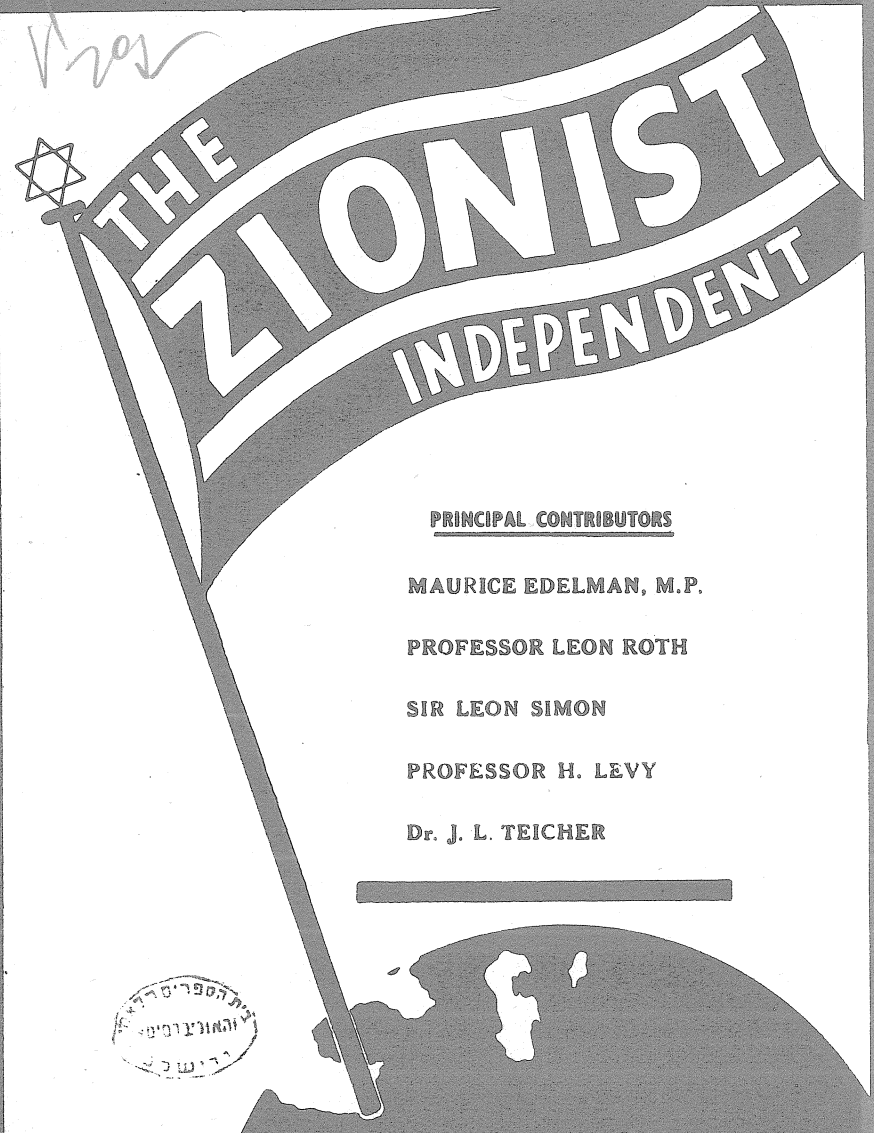
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EDITORIAL

Israel, the Galuth and The Universities

Israel survived. Zionists knew that Jewish Nationalism was one of the "irresistible forces of history," and we were as certain as was Herzl in 1897, that within a short period of years, a Jewish State would rise again. This has come about, and the time has now been reached for us to survey our position.

Our first responsibility is to see that we, as Jews, play our part in the upbuilding and strengthening of Israel. In the educational and cultural sphere—a sphere in which we as university students have a special interest—the Galuth can perform important services. One cannot ascertain exactly to what degree Jewish students, research scientists, and academicians can make a contribution to Israel. But one thing is certain; there is sufficient good Jewish material in the Galuth to enable Jerusalem once again to take its proper place within the ranks of the leading seats of learning in the world. Let our top-grade University men go to Mount Scopus, and let the scholarship and learning of Jews again become essentially Jewish. Let Israel, and not the other nations of the world, receive the credit and pride from Jewish achievement. Furthermore, from Universities outside Israel must come many of the trained technicians required for all branches of industry, commerce and government service.

For many years to come, Israel will only be able to support and absorb a small proportion of World Jewry. Obviously therefore, there will remain large Jewish communities outside. Some say that these do not matter, and that those Jews who desire to go to Israel should do so, and that the remainder should attempt to assimilate. This has seriously been put forward as a solution to the Jewish Problem. We have seen the sorry results of attempts at assimilation, and those of us who reject this contention, and want to preserve the Jewish Communities, must attack and defeat this tendency wherever we find it: for it is realistic and important to recognise that Israel

I.A. and the Hebrew University

PROFESSOR LEON ROTH

I SUPPOSE few of my readers will recognise the initials I.A. or remember the name or the personality behind them, but I have used them deliberately in order to call the attention of our younger generation to an Anglo-Jewish University man who did more than anyone else in his day to keep alive a spirit which can fairly be called humanist, I do not know whether his books are still read. They certainly deserve to be. Even his occasional trifles are of interest; and he had a gift of treating serious matters with a deftness of touch which reminds the reader of the medicine of one novel a day which he used to take regularly after lunch. Israel Abrahams was not a great philosopher, or a great philologist, or a great Talmudist, but he was very nearly a great man, and he was that because of all the Jewish scholars of his day he was one of the few who possessed not only scholarship but vision. His attitude to the second part of my title offers an instructive instance.

We have all been brought up to believe that the idea of the Hebrew University of Jerusalem is due to Hermann Schapira of Heidelberg. I once looked up the reference and found to my surprise that Hermann Schapira had no such idea. He envisaged a *German* University for Jews to be set up *somewhere in the settlements!* Even the Weizmann-Feivel-Buber plan of 1901-3 for a Juedische Hochschule only sought

PROFESSOR LEON ROTH, M.A., D.Phil.—Educated at the City of London School and Exeter College, Oxford. He is Achad Ha-am Professor of Philosophy at the Hebrew University, where he was Rector from 1940-1943. He was elected an Officier d'Académie in 1926. His many publications include works on Spinoza, Maimonides, Descartes, Achad Ha-am, Modern Philosophy, and Modern Political Thought.

to provide a substitute for Jewish students deprived of the chance of higher technical education in Russia and Rumania. It would appear that the idea of a Hebrew University of Jerusalem, that is, a University which should be a University, and which should be in Hebrew and in Jerusalem "as of right" (as it were) and "not on sufferance," a University which should be not only for Jewish students but for Judaism in its original creative language and in its original creative home—this idea was first given publicity (it would seem) by I.A., and in the columns of the "Jewish Chronicle" (28 February, 1908).

I.A. saw that the kernel of the University should be Jewish studies and hoped that in Jerusalem there would be a concentration of available talent, but at the same time he understood that a University must be a University and contain all faculties. He was strongly opposed, as in practice so in theory, to the isolation of Jewish studies, and he saw clearly that the very idea of a University precluded a college confined to Rabbinics or even to humanistic subjects. There was evidently at the time a "narrower" and a "wider" scheme, and I.A. was for the "wider." That is what one would have expected, and we need only note the fact. What is surprising is that, whereas Hermann Schapira (writing in a Hebrew paper) and the authors of the 1901-3 scheme seem to have been convinced that a University must be run in German, and even Schapira himself could only envisage Hebrew becoming a spoken language as a future possibility, I.A., writing, it is true, in 1908, had no doubt at all that the language of the University should be Hebrew. "In Jerusalem of course," he writes "the language of tuition and intercourse would be Hebrew"; and adds: "this surely would be of itself an inestimable gain."

A leading article in the same issue of the "Jewish Chronicle" strongly supported the plan for a Jerusalem University, and I quote a central passage:—

"In a great Jewish University at the very centre of our people's aspirations and hopes, it is quite possible there may be found the solvent of many problems, religious, social, political, economic, which to-day confront us. A new era may begin for Jewry, a new era ushered in by the best traditions

which Jewry has ever cherished. For a Jewish University would take its place, and we venture to think a very high place, among the seats of learning of the world. This in its turn could not fail to enhance the status of the Jew wherever he may be, by at once linking him in the world's estimate with something tangibly great and noble and associating him with something big and worthy which would elevate his aspirations and enrich his ideals."

I presume that such writing would be considered now out of date. Few among us now care to be thought to care for "ideals," and few care for what "the world" thinks. But does it not remain true even to-day (or perhaps especially to-day) that, quite apart from the estimate of the world, we should strive, for the sake of our own souls, to be linked with the great and noble?

Haganah Day

S. HARELI

ON the 11th of Adar (12 March), Israel celebrated Haganah Day, in commemoration of Joseph Trumpeldor and his comrades who were killed in their heroic defence of Tel Hai, an outlying settlement in Upper Galilee, in 1920.

The long and heroic history of Haganah has not yet been written, but every village and town of Israel are living reminders of its work and achievements since the beginning of our national revival up till our present defence of Israel.

The idea of Haganah, that is, the self-defence of the Yishuv against attacks, was first conceived in the seventies of the last century, when a small lonely group of pioneers left Jerusalem and went to settle on the land. They worked the land by the sweat of their brows and defended it with their blood. These first pioneers persevered alone in their toil and struggle until they were able to hand over their ploughs and guns to the more numerous pioneers who had come from the Diaspora to dedicate their lives too to the upbuilding of the Land of Israel. And so the Yishuv grew and developed into a community of builders and defenders who paved the way for scores of thousands of newcomers.

It was a Jerusalem Rabbi, Akiba Joseph Shlesinger, who, while giving himself up to mystic and devotional pursuits, first urged the organising of "Guardians of the Lord" and "Fighters of the Lord," the former to work the land and the latter to ward off attackers. However, for many years the defence of the Yishuv remained unorganised and the settlements had to provide for their own protection.